If Netanyahu and Herzog had been forced to form a unity government, Odeh could have become Israel's first Palestinian opposition leader. He downplayed that, too. "We shouldn't be talking about Arab or Jewish," he said. "We should be talking about citizens."

What is Zionism?

One night in early January, with the snow still melting from the year's first winter storm, voters schlepped into a religious seminary in Jerusalem to hear a succession of right-wing candidates warn that the Supreme Court and the US State Department were conspiring to destroy Israel.

The leaders of most political parties in Israel choose their candidates by fiat. Jewish Home is one of the few that holds primaries. The party's leader, Naftali Bennett, seems in many ways like an Israeli dispatched straight from central casting: an officer in the elite Sayeret Matkal commando unit, then a millionaire high-tech entrepreneur, and finally a charismatic politician who speaks fluent English. He took over the creaky half-century-old National Religious Party in late 2012 and, within one election cycle, raised it from three seats to twelve.

It was still widely seen, however, as a far-right faction for religious settlers. Bennett wanted to change that. He had an eye on the prime minister's office, and to get there he needed to transform Jewish Home into a broader right-wing party. So he recruited a handful of secular candidates, most notably Eli Ohana, a popular football star whose support for the 2005 Gaza disengagement was anathema to the party faithful. Activists joked that Bennett had stuffed the rabbis and settlers in the closet until after the primary. Instead he released photos from a paintballing trip with two secular candidates from Tel Aviv.

It was an ambitious ploy, and a well-timed one, with so many disenchanted Likudniks. But the thing about democracy, as Bennett once said, is that it lets the people decide—and his people were still on the far right. At the primary event in Jerusalem, one prospective candidate promised to gut Israel's high court, saying that the liberal justices "make it very difficult to strengthen the Jewish identity of the state… they always come and cancel the laws." Another questioned Lieberman's right-wing credentials, and vowed to "Judaize" occupied East Jerusalem, "putting more and more Jews in and breaking up the continuity that the Arabs have." A